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Long walk out of the tunnel

The ISL's comeback offers relief, not romance. Behind the kick-off lies a warning about money, trust and the **fragility of the system.**

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"Estamos bien en el Refugio los 33" was immortalised in Chile after the Copiapó mining accident. In 2010, 33 mine workers were presumed dead after a cave-in in the Atacama Desert.

Seventeen days later, all were rescued alive and unharmed. The key to the operation was a dusty note in Spanish that translated to: "We are well in refuge, all 33", one that kept the rescue team motivated to extract the workers alive.

Hope at the end of a tunnel arrives as a harbinger of relief.

The same lifeline, hope, seems to have rekindled Indian football, dragging it out after months of despondency. The 2025-26 season of the Indian Super League (ISL), the top-flight of men's football in the country, is finally happening.

Football Sports Development Limited (FSDL), which owned the league, saw its Master Rights Agreement (MRA) with the All India Football Federation (AIFF) expire on December 8, 2025.

But the two parties failed to agree on an extension, plunging the league into uncertainty and putting thousands of livelihoods at stake: players, referees, groundsmen, match officials, to name a few.

"We initially realised there was some sort of lack of trust between the clubs and the Federation, which was resolved through discussions," says Indian Football Association Secretary Anirban Dutta, one of the three members of the committee formed to fast-track the start of the league.

"From the beginning, we said that if this league, the premier division, doesn't happen, Indian football will go back 100 years... Now that the league is happening, there is no greater achievement than this."

The AIFF first assured the clubs of a long-term vision for the next 20 seasons and then proposed an agenda for a truncated 2025-26. The plan was accepted by the clubs and approved by the Asian Football Confederation (AFC).

A fresh tender for media rights was floated, and *FanCode* eventually bagged the broadcasting rights for Rs. 8.62 crore. *Kaleidoscope Services* took the production rights for Rs. 5.2 crore.

The ISL will begin with champion Mohun Bagan Super Giant taking on three-time runner-up Kerala Blasters in the opener at the Salt Lake Stadium on February 14.

Not a bed of roses

The upcoming campaign, however, will not be a bed of roses.

Fourteen teams will play 91 matches until May 17, with each side playing 13 games, once against every club. Compared to last season, that's a 50 per cent fall: half of the average 26. Teams played at least 24